

5 Colours, backgrounds and images

The very essence of CSS is that it allows us to separate the presentation from content. The entire core content including the text and key images are locked in the HTML, leaving all the actual styling separate in a style sheet. Therefore, the style sheet is where all the design material is specified. This includes the colour and placement of decorative images. CSS allows you to apply colour to text and containers, the application of background images etc.

Background images are key to realizing the creative potential of CSS-based web design, and they literally transform your pages into works of art if used properly. It should be noted that adding any images to a page, whether inline or with CSS, will increase its weight, and therefore the time it takes to download. Many designers do more harm than good using CSS to apply unnecessarily large photographic backgrounds and complicated images. This when combined with other heavy ingredients such as JavaScript, significantly increases a page's total size. The trick is to use background images sparingly and creatively. It also helps to be aware of occasions where the same image can be reused and repositioned on a page.

Advanced CSS deals specifically with incredibly ambitious background image use, but these processes can be slightly complex. In this chapter, you will first learn the correct ways of applying colour to your web pages and later begin to work with background images in a sensible way.

5.1 Colours

Let us work with the notion that there are only 216 colours that you may use on your web pages. Early web designers were bound by many rules that restricted their choices. Among the many limitations, one of the most widely adopted was the concept of a web-safe colour. 216 colours were guaranteed to be displayed correctly on any platform the page is displayed in, and the problem of using any others was that they could be rendered differently on different browsers or not rendered at all. But fortunately most modern browsers allow for millions of colours.

5.1.1 Web-safe Colours

Web-safe palettes or browser-safe palettes consist of 216 colours that display solidly, consistently, and without gradation on any monitor capable of